

The Nobel Prize for Literature 2011 Hoax

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About half an hour before the official announcement of the Nobel Prize for Literature, 2011 (which was awarded to Tomas Tranströmer) reports started circulating on Twitter that the winner was, controversially, the Serbian author, Dobrica Cosic. The source was <http://www.nobelprizeliterature.org>, which looked like this:

 Fake Nobel announcement

Smelling a rat, as the official site is nobelprize.org, I decided to check it out.

The first result was a probe from the Linux DNS lookup utility, dig, which revealed the following differences between the sites:

```
martin@allusion:~$ dig nobelprizeliterature.org
```

```
; <<>> DiG 9.7.3 <<>> nobelprizeliterature.org
;; global options: +cmd
;; Got answer:
;; ->>HEADER<<- opcode: QUERY, status: NOERROR, id: 3516
;; flags: qr rd ra; QUERY: 1, ANSWER: 1, AUTHORITY: 3, ADDITIONAL: 3

;; QUESTION SECTION:
;nobelprizeliterature.org.      IN      A

;; ANSWER SECTION:
nobelprizeliterature.org. 14400 IN      A      67.205.43.34

;; AUTHORITY SECTION:
nobelprizeliterature.org. 86265 IN      NS      ns2.dreamhost.com.
nobelprizeliterature.org. 86265 IN      NS      ns1.dreamhost.com.
nobelprizeliterature.org. 86265 IN      NS      ns3.dreamhost.com.

;; ADDITIONAL SECTION:
ns1.dreamhost.com.      8989  IN      A      66.33.206.206
ns2.dreamhost.com.      7503  IN      A      208.96.10.221
ns3.dreamhost.com.      7485  IN      A      66.33.216.216

;; Query time: 183 msec
;; SERVER: 10.8.0.1#53(10.8.0.1)
;; WHEN: Thu Oct 6 11:56:24 2011
;; MSG SIZE rcvd: 173
```

```
martin@allusion:~$ dig nobelprize.org
```

```
; <<>> DiG 9.7.3 <<>> nobelprize.org
;; global options: +cmd
;; Got answer:
;; ->>HEADER<<- opcode: QUERY, status: NOERROR, id: 27771
;; flags: qr rd ra; QUERY: 1, ANSWER: 1, AUTHORITY: 0, ADDITIONAL: 0

;; QUESTION SECTION:
;nobelprize.org.              IN      A

;; ANSWER SECTION:
nobelprize.org.      3505  IN      A      130.242.18.28

;; Query time: 29 msec
;; SERVER: 10.8.0.1#53(10.8.0.1)
;; WHEN: Thu Oct 6 11:56:29 2011
;; MSG SIZE rcvd: 48
```

As is clear, the latter, authentic site is running on it's own independent IP address, while the former points to the commercial web host provider Dreamhost.

Secondly, here's a comparison of the DNS whois responses for the two domains. Firstly, for the fake entry:

martin@allusion:~\$ whois nobelprizeliterature.org

NOTICE: Access to .ORG WHOIS information is provided to assist persons in determining the contents of a domain name registration record in the Public Interest Registry

registry database. The data in this record is provided by Public Interest Registry for informational purposes only, and Public Interest Registry does not guarantee its accuracy. This service is intended only for query-based access. You agree that you will use this data only for lawful purposes and that, under no circumstances will you use this data to: (a) allow, enable, or otherwise support the transmission by e-mail, telephone, or facsimile of mass unsolicited, commercial advertising or solicitations to entities other than the data recipient's own existing customers; or (b) enable high volume, automated, electronic processes that send queries or data to the systems of Registry Operator or any ICANN-Accredited Registrar, except as reasonably necessary to register domain names or modify existing registrations. All rights reserved. Public Interest Registry reserves the right to modify these terms at any time. By submitting this query, you agree to abide by this policy.

Domain ID:D163518199-LROR

Domain Name:NOBELPRIZELITERATURE.ORG

Created On:05-Oct-2011 15:13:54 UTC

Last Updated On:05-Oct-2011 16:42:08 UTC

Expiration Date:05-Oct-2012 15:13:54 UTC

Sponsoring Registrar:Directi Internet Solutions Pvt. Ltd. d/b/a

PublicDomainRegistry.com (R27-LROR)

Status:CLIENT TRANSFER PROHIBITED

Status:TRANSFER PROHIBITED

Status:ADDPERIOD

Registrant ID:DI_18210988

Registrant Name:Gjord Halvorsen

Registrant Organization:NPABL

Registrant Street1:Brynjulf Bulls Plass 1

Registrant Street2:

Registrant Street3:

Registrant City:Oslo

Registrant State/Province:Oslo

Registrant Postal Code:0124

Registrant Country:NO

Registrant Phone:+49.301000

Registrant Phone Ext.:

Registrant FAX:

Registrant FAX Ext.:

Registrant Email:hgjorn@yahoo.com

Admin ID:DI_18210988

Admin Name:Gjord Halvorsen

Admin Organization:NPABL

[illegible]

whereas the official site is registered thus:

`martin@allusion:~$ whois nobelprize.org`

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registry database. The data in this record is provided by Public Interest Registry for informational purposes only, and Public Interest Registry does not guarantee its accuracy. This service is intended only for query-based access. You agree that you will use this data only for lawful purposes and that, under no circumstances will you use this data to: (a) allow, enable, or otherwise support the transmission by e-mail, telephone, or facsimile of mass unsolicited, commercial advertising or solicitations to entities other than the data recipient's own existing customers; or (b) enable high volume, automated, electronic processes that send queries or data to the systems of Registry Operator or any ICANN-Accredited Registrar, except as reasonably necessary to register domain names or modify existing registrations. All rights reserved. Public Interest Registry reserves the right to modify these terms at any time. By submitting this query, you agree to abide by this policy.

Domain ID:D2213820-LROR

Domain Name:NOBELPRIZE.ORG

Created On:17-Oct-1998 04:00:00 UTC

Last Updated On:19-Jul-2011 12:19:42 UTC

Expiration Date:16-Oct-2013 04:00:00 UTC

Sponsoring Registrar:Domaininfo AB, aka domaininfo.com (R29-LROR)

Status:CLIENT TRANSFER PROHIBITED

Registrant ID:DI-235-THE

Registrant Name:Domain Name Department

Registrant Organization:The Nobel foundation

Registrant Street1:c/o Dipcon AB, William Gibsons vag 1

Registrant Street2:

Registrant Street3:

Registrant City:Jonsered

Registrant State/Province:

Registrant Postal Code:43376

Registrant Country:SE

Registrant Phone:+46.317202030

Registrant Phone Ext.:

Registrant FAX:+46.317202039

Registrant FAX Ext.:

Registrant Email:dms@dipcon.com

Admin ID:DI-13-DEP

Admin Name:Domain Name Department

Admin Organization:Dipcon AB

Admin Street1:William Gibsons vag 1

Admin Street2:

Admin Street3:

[illegible]

While there is no guarantee that the information is genuine, journalists who wanted to pursue this further would only have to investigate this information on the registrant of the fake domain name:

Gjord Halvorsen

Brynjulf Bulls Plass 1

Oslo

0124

Norway

+49.301000

hgjorn@yahoo.com

The registrant has used the address of the official committee, so that's of no use. The name could, also, be fake. The only thing that would, probably need to be real there would be the email address.